United. That meant I could be at home, with my friends and family, while I turned fourteen and fifteen. And I could keep playing for Ridgeway Rovers, which by then had become a team called Brimsdown: we were the same players more or less, just the name had changed. United were happy for boys to get on with their lives and play for their Sunday League teams until they moved to the city. Malcolm Fidgeon would come and watch me play for Brimsdown and, as long as I was enjoying my soccer and playing regularly, that was enough. The time for United to take all the responsibility was still a couple of years away.

I used to go up to Manchester two or three times a year to train during the school vacations. In the summer, I'd be up there for the whole six weeks. I loved it and didn't want to do anything else with my time off from school but play and train and be at United. Those summers were fantastic. There would be thirty or so of us together at a time, all looked after by Malcolm and the rest of the coaching staff, in halls of residence. I'd think about the place where I'd stayed in Barcelona; that lovely old house with the mountains rising up behind us. This was a bit different: a concrete block in Salford, stuck on top of a hill and freezing cold. You shared a room with another young player, the facilities were basic but at least there was a snooker table and a table tennis table for us to use in the evenings.

Not that where we were staying made much difference to me. We'd go to United's second training ground at Lyttleton Road every day and train morning and afternoon. Then, in the evenings, we'd live it up: trips to the movies, fish and chips, all the glamorous stuff. I met other boys who had signed at the same time as me, like John O'Kane, who I spent a lot of time with back then. John was from Nottingham. He was a massive prospect at United all through our first years there together, a really good player. As a person, he was very relaxed. Maybe it was because he was so laid back that it didn't really workout for him at United. He ended up leaving to go to Everton, the season we went on to do the Treble, and is playing for Blackpool now.

Lads would come from everywhere for those vacation sessions. Keith Gillespie, who's now at Leicester, came over from Ireland. He was a lovely lad, and I used to get on really well with him. Colin Murdock, who's just moved from Preston to Hibs, came down from Scotland. We were all miles from home, in the same boat, and that made it easier for us all to get on, even if, in the back of our minds, we knew we were in competition with each other as well. The soccer was what mattered above everything and it was a new experience, training day in day out and being introduced to more technical